

Sixth Maxim: Act for the Future Generations of All Species

Bhante Bodhidhamma · Tips of the Day · 4 min read

Noirin Sheahan This tip looks at the last of the six maxims which have been suggested as ethical preparation for climate catastrophe. This advises us to “act for future generations of all species”. Here’s how the authors elaborate: Speak for those without voice: the poor, the future generations, other species. Speak for the forests, the seas, the mountains. Act, personally and politically, to limit the damage being done to the biosphere. Every 0.5° C increase avoided is a major victory and achievement. We are to concern ourselves with the welfare of those far beyond our circle of friendship or kinship. The Buddha’s teaching on compassion asks the same, and these lines from the Metta Sutta link closely with the maxim: Whatever living beings there may be, Whether they be weak or strong, omitting none, The great or the mighty, medium, short or tall, The seen and unseen, Those living near or far away, born or to-be-born, may all beings be at ease! The words are easy to say, but challenging to put into action. Weak or strong omitting none. Considering climate change, the weak could be considered as those currently suffering, for example peoples in East Africa who have suffered decades of drought with resultant famine, homelessness and political instability, war and mass migration. The strong could be considered as those in relatively stable environments like Europe and the US, long beneficiaries of the resource-hungry technologies causing climate change. It’s helpful to bring both weak and strong together as the tendency to blame can find no suitable resting place – neither the climate refugees nor the far-right activists opposing them, nor the climate deniers exacerbating the crisis. Weak and strong, omitting none. Neither can we console ourselves by ignoring the forecasts of what our grandchildren may have to face: Those born and to be born; May all beings be at ease. To “act for future generations of all species” is to consider the whole world, to let the mind linger on wildfires, floods, drought and the devastation these bring for people and wildlife as well as nature itself, the essential basis for new generations. When considering the world in this way, I’ve found it helpful to remember the Buddha’s teaching that the whole world can be found within this fathom long body. ‘The world’ here means the totality of our experience. In meditation we are normally focussed on our inner world of sensations and feelings. While working with this maxim, the totality of our experience includes our thoughts and imaginings of the outer world, planet earth with all its inhabitants. Imaging drought and starvation brings tension: the jaws clench, the eyes wince. We usually ignore these seemingly trivial reactions but they are a key to the conundrum of compassion: how do I open the heart to the suffering of the world without causing myself to suffer? Here is an example of working with this conundrum from my own experience. Remembering that ‘the world can be found within this fathom long body’ draws awareness towards the physical tension in my jaws, eyes and elsewhere. This gives me the objectivity needed to register aversion, the attempt to get rid of suffering. Tracking the

pushing sensations of aversion I realise that I am attempting to push away the imagined suffering so that 'I' can be above it all, directing good wishes towards those who suffer. At times I sense this image of myself as superior, powerful, full of resources, while 'the world' is weak and needy. This is pity, easily confused with compassion. As I acknowledge pity, I notice how exhausting it is to imagine myself above the suffering of the world, how much effort I have to put into my good wishes. In time I run out of steam and sense myself as drowning in the imagined suffering of the world. Anger, blame and despair compete for attention as I scramble to get back on top of things. This is overwhelm, compassion fatigue, burn-out. Mindfully tracking experience as it bobs between these extremes, I find myself drawn towards a middle ground where the distinction between 'me' and 'the suffering of the world' is not so pronounced. This is a kind of no-mans-land and the lack of direction can be disconcerting, but since pity and overwhelm are dead ends I have no choice but to explore this territory. I sense my boundaries loosening as mental images and thoughts are pulled downwards into the body, making everything feel unstable, uncertain. It's nerve-wracking and the breath becomes jerky, but if I can stick with it long enough, a joyful fascination makes itself felt. Unpleasant sensations grow more pronounced, but habitual aversion towards them is held in check. I am now sensing these sensations as my best attempt to become conscious of the suffering of the world, while holding them in awareness is recognized as my best attempt at compassion. Although the sensations are unpleasant, the holding feels pleasant and thus a tentative equilibrium forms. Within this equilibrium, I see that the unpleasant sensation are caused by anger, which is being directed at the felt sense of myself as responsible for fixing this problem. With that, the expectation that I should be able to fix the problem fades. Instead of there being a bubble of 'me' holding all the responsibility to save the world, the resources now seem to be shared equally. I sense a growing confidence that an essential goodness will continue no matter what devastation may be forthcoming. The endeavor to expand my circle of goodwill has dissolved a layer of delusion, demonstrating the link between wisdom and compassion. With this more balanced perspective, it becomes easier to think about practical ways I could help – which charities I could support, which actions I could take as a personal or political level. The sixth maxim challenges us to expand our circle of concern towards all the inhabitants of the earth, including nature itself. The Buddha's teaching that 'the whole world can be found within this fathom-long body' provides a practical way to open the heart to meet this challenge.

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